

he had been born. In declining health by the 1970s, he struggled through illness to finish his last major work, the opera *Death in Venice*. Thomas Mann's story of a dying artist's obsession with an idealized boy was of obvious personal significance to Britten. First performed in 1973, the work is generally judged one of his finest achievements. Britten died of heart failure in 1976. He was buried in a simple churchyard in Aldeburgh, where Pears would later lie alongside him.